

► **PRIYANKA CHOPRA**
SWEETIE IN
KAMINEY

NO WILTING
WALLFLOWER,
SHE STANDS UP TO
HER POLITICIAN-
DON BROTHER,
FOLLOWING THE
DICTATES OF HER
HEART, NOT MIND

► **JESSE RANDHAWA**
AND **LISA HAYDON**

IN THE BAJAJ AD,
TWISTED SISTERS
FIGHT EACH OTHER
FOR THE PRIVILEGE
OF RIDING A BIKE.
MORE VIXEN-LIKE
SISTER WINS

topographer's studio striking poses and practising her *Indian Idol* moves while her fuddy-duddy father tries in vain to get her married to the first available man. It's like the Nokia ad featuring Chopra cavorting in her short pajamas says, we're hot, we're hotter, we're naughty, we're nice.

Much of the new assertion has to do with the coming of age of reality TV in India, which has allowed audiences to watch an unvarnished version of women, and made stars of item girls Rakhi Sawant and Sambhavna

choosing to stay home than stay underfoot. As newbie Gill says, "I've read 10 scripts after *Dev.D* but haven't liked a single character." Today, even the minor women characters on screen have spirit. Anyone for Dolly, the ravenous sister in *Oye Lucky! Lucky Oye!*? She gets her English syntax mangled and her drinks mixed but leaves Lucky in no doubt about wanting his body, even if she's not "hi-fi."

It's an urban phenomenon that is not restricted to the big cities. As Patil says in *MTV 6.0*'s auditions, over 25 per cent of the 30,000 youngsters who auditioned were women, compared to



► **PALAK**
IN *MTV ROADIES 6.0*
ABUSIVE, TOUGH,
PRONE TO PHYSICAL
BOUTS WITH
CONTESTANTS.
OFTEN HAD TO
BE PEELED OFF
HER OPPONENT

Seth. Their gung-ho garrulousness has got audiences to look beyond the Kanjeevarams and cupcakes brigade as they gossip, flirt, and fight in their T-shirts and sweats. Sawant has parlayed her free range persona into a sort of subterranean stardom where she is even selecting a groom for herself on national TV and Seth has become a serial reality show contestant. So if the strong women in earlier Bollywood were portrayed as shrews waiting to be straightened out by their own Petruchios, now they seem more intent on teaching the guys some lessons in love. Or at least as Aretha Franklin would say earning respect, whether it is Bipasha Basu making Ranbir Kapoor do her domestic chores in *Bachna Ae Haseeno* or Konkana Sen Sharma refusing to dry her love rat boyfriend's tears in *Luck by Chance*.

It's a short-cut generation that doesn't have time even to suffer. As the new Airtel says, with feet tapping outside lift doors and fingers flying over keyboards, impatience is the new life. And in this new life, women are

just 10 per cent for the first season, from as many as 40 cities and towns. The ratings have also doubled, from 0.7 TRP in Season One to 1.6 this time, in the 15-24 age group in the Hindi-speaking markets. Where does fiction begin and reality take over? It's easy. If a Hero Honda 100cc Pleasure-riding Chopra makes fun of the NRI looking for the silly village girl in Punjab, then small town Chandigarh has also emerged as a major catchment area for *Roadies* girls, whether it's former finalist Bani or Palak.

Increasingly, women are trying to step out of the genre defined roles and be someone, like Anushka Sharma's character in *Rab Ne Bana Di Jodi*, be as adept at sweeping the house as they are at riding a motorcycle. As Dutt Guptan says, "They are no longer just cut-outs. They have a voice too, and it's often loud and harsh." ■